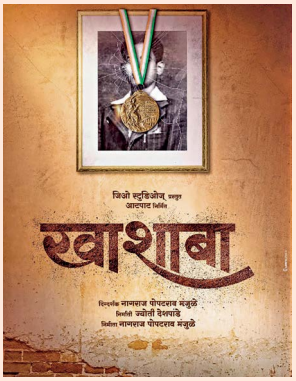
MARATHI FILMS TO WATCH OUT FOR

KHASHABA

After a not-so-successful outing in Bollywood, Nagraj Manjule returns to Marathi cinema. He's got composers Ajay-Atul by his side to tell the incredible but little-known story of Khashaba Jadhav, a wrestler from Satara, Maharashtra, who, against all odds, won India its first individual Olympic medal in 1952.



RAAVSAAHEB

Director Nikhil Mahajan teams up with writers Prajakt Deshmukh, Shripad Deshpande and Jeejivisha Kale to create a thriller about the battle between forest officials and the wildlife mafia.





MARDINI

Shreyas Talpade and wife Deepti produce what is billed as an intense drama about a beleagured mother who finally fights back. Starring Prarthana Behere, Jitendra Joshi and Myra Vaikul, it marks the feature directorial debut of Ajay Baikar, better known for his run in Marathi television.



EKATI

Cinematographer Archana Borhade, who co-wrote and produced *Karkhanisanchi Waari*, sits in the director's chair in this drama. Sakhi Gokhale plays Meera, a filmmaker who retreats to a coastal village to heal from a broken engagement, only to discover unnerving secrets.

ambaycha Nahi (There is No Stopping Now), about the lives and aspirations of municipal workers. Marathi cinema, after all, has a legacy flowing down from such greats as Dadasaheb Phalke and V. Shantaram, with directors like Umesh Kulkarni, Nagraj Manjule and Ravi Jadhav making their mark in recent years. The industry first got national attention with *Shwaas* (2004), the heartbreaking tale of a grandfather and his visually-impaired grandson, which became India's entry in the foreign film category at the Oscars. Ten years later, Chaitanya Tamhane's debut, *Court*, about a protest singer's travails through Mumbai's legal system, won the National Film Award and the Orizzonti award at the Venice Film festival.

PITFALLS AND POTENTIAL

But funding remains a challenge for some. "The issue with Marathi cinema has been long-term support," says Takalkar. "Isolated excellence cannot be confused with a thriving industry. There is a great deal of anxiety within Marathi cinema about audiences, theatrical support, budgets and visibility. Sometimes, it also underestimates itself creatively."



"I AM GRATEFUL FOR MARATHI CINEMA'S FOOTPRINT BUT IT NEEDS A LOT MORE ATTENTION. IF PEOPLE CAN WATCH KOREAN FILMS WITH SUBTITLES, WHY NOT MARATHI FILMS?"

JEEJIVISHA KALE
Director, *Tighee*

Unlike Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam films, Marathi films face another obstacle: a limited geographic footprint. At home, they contend with Bollywood, which usurps screens with the sheer volume of films produced, star power on display and larger-than-life stories.

Streaming platforms, barring ZEE5, have not invested in voices from the Marathi entertainment ecosystem, be it in features or long-format storytelling. "If people can watch Korean films with subtitles, then they can surely watch Marathi ones too," says Kale.

There's hope on the horizon, though. Hema V.R., business head, Marathi ZEE5, notes how viewership of Marathi films is expanding to Karnataka, Gujarat, Goa, Telangana, Karnataka and Delhi. The industry's "meaningful content" is driving a 38 per cent jump in subscriptions. "This signals a real shift," she says. Riteish Deshmukh's Mumbai Film Company has shown that Marathi films can be money-spinners, as with *Lai Bhaari* (2014) and *Ved* (2022), and now *Raja Shivaji* becoming the highest-grossing Marathi film ever. Meanwhile, Nagraj Manjule, whose star-crossed romance *Sairat* (2016) struck a chord, directs one of Jio Studios' big Marathi offerings: *Khashaba*. A biopic on the titular wrestler who won independent India its first ever individual Olympic medal, Manjule hopes to repeat the feat he accomplished with *Sairat:* make a pan-India Marathi film.

"The future of Marathi cinema," says Takalkar, "lies not in becoming a smaller version of Hindi cinema, but in becoming more specific, more emotionally contemporary and more fearless in its own voice." ■